Ravi Katam - **11:05**

Hey, Eric.

Eric Zelman - **11:06**

Hey, Robbie. How are you?

Ravi Katam - **11:08**

Good, good. How are you doing?

Eric Zelman - **11:10**

I'm great. Or I'm. I'm. I'm alive somewhere in between those two.

Ravi Katam - **11:17**

What's this? Fireflies? Is that your AI agent?

Eric Zelman - **11:22**

It is, it is. And I'm, you know, I have to do something about this background because my head just keeps blurring out and it looks so weird. Hang on a second here.

Ravi Katam - **11:34**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **11:35**

Because I'm playing around with Google Meets is an alternative to Zoom and I'm not sure if I like it.

Ravi Katam - **11:44**

Yeah, I never really liked Google Meets.

Eric Zelman - **11:47**

Yeah, it's kind of like a cheaper. I mean, it's just cheaper.

Ravi Katam - **11:52**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **11:53**

Yeah. What's new with you?

Ravi Katam - **11:59**

Not much. Just going through the interviews.

Eric Zelman - **12:04**

That's great.

Ravi Katam - **12:05**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **12:07**

Have you had.

Ravi Katam - **12:08**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **12:10**

So you have traction on your resume?

Ravi Katam - **12:14**

Yeah, yeah. I just had a final round of interview with one of the companies, so we'll see what happens.

Eric Zelman - **12:21**

Oh, that's awesome.

Ravi Katam - **12:22**

Yeah. Yeah, that. I had five interviews so far, so I will know either today or Monday if they're going to make an offer or not, but. Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **12:37**

Wow.

Ravi Katam - **12:38**

Yeah. And then I stopped. I kind of stopped applying. Because there's so much you're gonna, you know, you can apply in. Yeah, I kind of. I took, I took a break applying and then now, you know.

Eric Zelman - **12:58**

How many of you applied to? I mean, in total, how many did you apply to?

Ravi Katam - **13:04**

Probably like 20, 30.

Eric Zelman - **13:07**

That's an amazing signal to noise ratio that you've had five interviews and off of 20 or 30 applications. So that's really. I mean, that's really. That's great.

Ravi Katam - **13:21**

I don't know if it's great or not, but, you know, at least I got some practice, right? Doing the interview. So how are you doing? Any traction on your side?

Eric Zelman - **13:34**

Really? Nothing? No. Yeah, not much. I. I don't know. I'm up to about 140, so. And I just had nothing in the last week or two.

Ravi Katam - **13:51**

I see.

Eric Zelman - **13:52**

Yeah. I mean, I've applied to a few more, but I mean, I just don't get any responses, so. Might be barking up the wrong tree.

Ravi Katam - **14:02**

Any, any opportunities like that progressed and then materialize?

Eric Zelman - **14:12**

I mean, a few. I mean, of those 140, I would say that I've had four or five. I mean, yeah, probably maybe five or six interviews. And a couple were things that just stalled out because the company just either couldn't hire or had fun. You know, they had their own problems. Others, we just weren't a good fit. But they never really formally told me that they, you know, just sort of disappeared. But yeah, and then a couple where I didn't get past the, I didn't really, you know, like I would just interview or I wouldn't get past the first round with the HR people. So it's interesting, you know, I mean I, I'm trying to keep moving, you know, I'm trying to figure out.

Ravi Katam - **15:08**

Yeah, what I'm seeing is the smaller companies are. Like startups and early growth companies. They are looking for, you know, they're very particular about who they're hiring and they also want to hire for less. They don't want to pay too much, they want a lot of experience, which there is a lot of. There are a lot of people out there looking for jobs.

Eric Zelman - **15:41**

So I mean I've been putting in, you know, like where I would be fine coming on board for like 125 or even 100 in some places. So I mean I'm not, I mean, I think that I'm appropriately pricing, you know, to be competitive with what's there. Also, I mean I, I did it. I, you know, I love AI things so much because they let me make, they let me rapidly display information. So this is, I wasn't, I didn't know were going to talk about this, but this is a funny chart that I made today and let me share my screen and show this to you. This might, this might say a lot or you know,

your entire screen. So I know my screen is, the resolution is kind of large, but here is this. Can you see that?

Ravi Katam - **16:52**

Yeah. What, what does it mean?

Eric Zelman - **16:55**

So what this is these are all these, this is not, I mean there's some jobs that weren't that were just like apply via LinkedIn or whatever, but this is roughly, this is like 90% of the jobs I've applied to and where they fit. And so this is breaking them down by, on the Y axis is their title like vp, Senior Director, senior Manager, Team manager, you know, IC roles like CSM Manager or CS manager. And I think some of that's a bit off because I think most of the CSM roles are just IC roles, but the, you know, AI parsing got it wrong. But this is basically just sort of shows the cadence and sort of population of what I've been applying for.

Eric Zelman - **17:42**

And I'm not really applying for senior roles, I'm applying for things that tend to be less on the people management role. I mean, it does say 90%, but again, I think Most of those. I think it's, I think it gets confused between customer success manager and Customer success manager as an individual contributor. Because I think it doesn't understand that just because it says manager, that isn't a manager of people, you know, necessarily. Right. So this is kind of just my scatter shot of like how my application process is broken down or has. So did you get a chance to try my gadget?

Ravi Katam - **18:33**

I tried the lens and that's about. Is there anything else that I, I can try or. I thought that was. Well, I mean.

Eric Zelman - **18:43**

So did you fill out the feedback form?

Ravi Katam - **18:46**

I did.

Eric Zelman - **18:46**

You did. Okay. So. And you. And so you felt. And apologies if my brain is destroyed. So you felt. I think from the feedback form I'm recalling, you felt that it asked you some redundant questions.

Ravi Katam - **19:04**

Redundant meaning like I already gave that information for another question, but he's asking for the same content again.

Eric Zelman - **19:14**

Right, right.

Ravi Katam - **19:16**

Because the question is fair, but I've already given that answer for another question, so appears redundant even though the question is different. Right.

Eric Zelman - **19:32**

But it feels like.

Ravi Katam - **19:34**

Yeah. And it seems like. And some of the questions are kind of similar. Right. Sometimes it actually starts asking. Digging into concrete examples that take. That took a while. I had to answer the same question five times, like five subsequent questions on the same topic until it's satisfied.

Eric Zelman - **20:02**

Right.

Ravi Katam - **20:03**

So that took a lot. Took a while because I really had to think through and what, you know, what information it's actually looking for. And I had gave it to AI, but I don't think it took any information from Resume or the pro LinkedIn profile, which I pasted. And it gives. Because in the essence, in the summary, it should take that into consideration. Right. So.

Eric Zelman - **20:30**

Well, it doesn't. So it doesn't know how to parse the URL of like a LinkedIn profile if you paste that into one.

Ravi Katam - **20:37**

No, I actually uploaded the PDF.

Eric Zelman - **20:39**

Oh, you uploaded the PDF. Okay.

Ravi Katam - **20:40**

Yeah, yeah. Download and upload. So based on the resume itself, Right. Specifically the summary of the resume is the customer success leader managing, you know, building. It's not in the essence.

Eric Zelman - **20:56**

Oh man, that's a big fail.

Ravi Katam - **20:58**

Yeah, I mean I would expect that everything else was okay. It matched what I input. But the essence itself, like that's the first thing everybody see. It didn't really portray me as a sex leader.

Eric Zelman - **21:17**

Right, right. Interesting. And, and overall how it took you like a long time to go through it, right?

Ravi Katam - **21:27**

Two hours. Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **21:29**

Oh man.

Ravi Katam - **21:29**

I timed it because. Yeah, I had an interview until like 6:30. I started at 6:15, 6:20. And then I. I finished it around 8:20.

Eric Zelman - **21:41**

I still owe you a beer, so.

Ravi Katam - **21:44**

No, it's okay. I mean, I'm just, you know, it's good to go through that exercise.

Eric Zelman - **21:49**

Well, I'm trying to refine it and sort of rein it in so that it isn't redundant or it's less redundant. Right. That it is faster, that it understands that sections shouldn't take that long. I think since the time that you tested it, I added a guide file for it that basically said if there's eight sections, don't make any of the sec. Don't make the person sit in this section for more than like five to eight minutes.

Ravi Katam - **22:20**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **22:21**

Because it's just. It's just too much. Right?

Ravi Katam - **22:24**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **22:25**

And. And it might go even shorter than that because I think that. I think that your experience is not what I want people to have and that. And that maybe the best way to do this might be to start off with like, you know, 25 minutes of questioning or 20 minutes of questioning, and then. And then have the ability to come back later and add to it and go deeper or something. If you wanted to, you know, versus being sucked into this really big time. Ask that. I don't know that everyone wants to give.

Ravi Katam - **23:04**

Yeah, yeah. I mean, especially. I think if we. Because especially when you mentioned it, like, it's going to take 30, 40 minutes. Then I felt like, okay, this is taking longer.

Eric Zelman - **23:16**

No, you probably felt mad because, like, Eric tricked me into two hours.

Ravi Katam - **23:20**

No, not mad because I. It. You know, when you see 30, 40 minutes ups, where you kind of your brain conditions to, okay, I'm gonna spend 30, 40 minutes. Right. And then it's taking. Well, that f. I felt like, am I doing something wrong here or am I not answering correctly? Or I go into that, you know, thinking where, okay, it's taking too long. I'm not doing it right. Is it. Is it working? Or, you know, kind of. Those kind of questions would come up. But if you say in the beginning it takes two hours, it should have been fine.

Eric Zelman - **23:59**

Right, Right, right. Yeah. Right. It's with the extrication. You said. Said it. And you put that perfectly because your customer success and you know how to set up, I guess, the proper expectation.

Ravi Katam - **24:14**

Right? Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **24:17**

Okay, let's see. So I learned a few interesting things this week about it from talking to different folks who. And Jared Hips tried it and he had a similar experience. So that was interesting to hear back from him. There was a bit of redundancy. It didn't take as long. So I think the guardrails are helping, but it's still a little bit redundant in the version that he tried. I've revved it since you did it. Right. I've made a couple of improvements. I've also added just for my own tracking code so that now when people try, can report on how long each session took and populated a table for me of each trial. Because I think that, you know, I. Again, when I coming back to. Sorry, I was a little bit discombobulated.

Eric Zelman - **25:19**

Coming back to what you were saying about how long it was taking. I think that's. The early versions that was a bit. That's a big concern. You know, I don't want it to go into like full psychoanalysis mode on people, you know, like, you must, because, you know, it just doesn't have any concept of time. And it needed to understand that people have, you know, it's saying 25 to 45 minutes or 25 to 50 minutes or whatever it says in that framework. So, you

know, again, it's about following through on that expectation. Some feedback I got from running the business idea by some people, and I wanted to ask you what you thought about this and if you've had this experience. Have you ever worked with an executive recruiter before?

Ravi Katam - **26:03**

No.

Eric Zelman - **26:06**

So I haven't either. And I met the former head of executive recruiting for Goldman Sachs. She worked there for like 30 years. She's like a friend of my father in law. She retired like 13, 14 years ago. But I was like, this is an amazing person to talk to because, like, you know, anyhow. So, yeah, she was telling me that a tool like this, she could see it in executive recruiting because the idea of, I mean, she didn't test it out. I didn't, you know, she. But the idea of something that, that helps a, a recruiter get a better understanding of a. Of a candidate with a long career could be really helpful and that this might have a place more in executive recruiting than like, as a frontline thing.

Ravi Katam - **27:05**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **27:06**

So I'm, you know, I'm still trying to play around with it and see where that goes. I'd love, you know, I mean, Robbie, you're under, you know, like, we're. As. It's, it's really generous of you to try it out. If you feel like trying it out again. I've made improvements, but I don't want to make you spend hours and hours.

Ravi Katam - **27:22**

Now I can try it again. Yeah, it's all right. It's good practice for Me. Yeah, and,.

Eric Zelman - **27:32**

Yeah, see. See how it goes. Also, the other thing I added to it is this idea that people might get frustrated and might just tell it after a bit to move on and for it to be aware of that, because they're just going to be like, this is taking too

long in this section, or I don't. Or they just feel like they don't have much more to add at that section. So.

Ravi Katam - **27:50**

Yeah, so I mean, what I would suggest is. No, I went through the same thing, just the guidelines. You can say you don't. You do not have to keep. Sit there and answer every question that the AI is asking. You can say, I don't know. I don't have that information. Right. I did that. Actually, one of the questions, because it's kept asking for more information. It's like, I don't have that information. Right. Like it's asking, how do you know if the culture of the company that's going to hire you is going. Is good? How do you know the. What are the signals? You see, the hiring manager is good or not fits your, you know, ideal manager? I don't know it based on. It's based on the conversation I pick up. It's. It's human signals. Not necessarily.

Ravi Katam - **28:35**

I can just not, you know, things like, you know, based on the context and the discussion we're having. I can pick up signals. Right, right. I don't have specific set of signals. I can say, tell AI that hey, this is my ideal manager. Right? Yeah, I, I kept providing the information. At some point I was like, okay, I don't know, because it's based on the context and discussion. I just left it there and then it took it. It's fine. Okay. Ravi said, you know, fuck off. He's like, I'm backing off. I'm going to move on to the next question. That's what he did. So I think in the guidelines, if you can say that, yeah, people would know. Okay, fine, I don't know. It's okay. No, is. I don't know is a good answer.

Eric Zelman - **29:18**

I think that's a great suggestion. I think it's a great suggestion. Did. Did any. And just to come back to the conclusion of it, did anything on the output give you any insights, any practical insights that you feel like are helping you in your job search currently or in how you will talk to people? I mean, I guess what I'm really asking here is do you think going through this exercise has any benefit other than helping your friend in terms of what you Know about yourself, your career, or what you're doing in these next few interviews.

Ravi Katam - **30:07**

So the exercise helped me. What I want. Right. But I can't say those things to the, to any of that. Can't share any of that information because I was candid, I was honest about things, what I like and what I want in order to. In my leaders and all of that. And I guess basically examples and what happened at Big Kin, Ken. Right. Those are good examples of what a leadership shouldn't be. I cannot provide any other information to you in the interviews. Right. So it helps me understand what I want. But, you know, like, if I have like five, three or four offers, then I. And then I want to pick one, then this would help me, which would be a better fit for me.

Eric Zelman - **31:04**

That's interesting.

Ravi Katam - **31:06**

But I'm just preparing for an interview. It has some information of how I work, what I do best, but not all of it, because that's where I'm saying it didn't get the information from the resume which had all my successes.

Eric Zelman - **31:25**

That's a, That's a. That's a big gap. I would say this. I would say this. What I want to. What I want to do is I'm going to go check the code and go look through this. What it should do, what I think is in that very first essence part, in the first question that it asks you, I want, and I will make sure this happens, or I'll try to make sure this happens. I want it to feedback that it has read some of those things, like saying, hey, Ravi, in this position that you were in, so that.

Ravi Katam - **31:59**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **32:00**

So you don't know the depth of its understanding necessarily. I mean, you hope it's read all these things, but at least it's signaling that it's. That it has read it and that it has some information, some context. Because I think that otherwise, you know, it feels like you're just uploading it and you're having this experience where you're like, didn't read anything and like, how is this influencing anything that's going on?

Ravi Katam - **32:22**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **32:22**

And it should read the whole thing.

Ravi Katam - **32:25**

I think that's a good point. Right. So when I started doing this, it's look at me as, like, what do you do? My first question is, what do you do? What do you mean, what do I do? I gave you my resume, LinkedIn profile on my customer success. I had to tell the AI that what I do, I think, to your point, if it goes and looks at my resume carefully and understand what I am what I've done so far. And then also LinkedIn profile and say, hey, Robbie, I'm gonna tell you what I know about you. This is what you are. Do you agree? Do you want to add anything more? Then people are like, oh, this is very interesting. AI is telling me something. Yes. It already knows something about me. Now I'm interested in spending more time here. It's human.

Ravi Katam - **33:22**

If somebody comes in and knows about you a little bit, hey, you're good at this. You had this experience. I really like about that experience. Tell me a little bit more. And people are invested in the time, right? So yeah, I think that's where the starting point is very important. So if you, if I can summarize what's in resume LinkedIn and say, this is what you are, tell me more about yourself.

Eric Zelman - **33:48**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **33:48**

Or does it make sense?

Eric Zelman - **33:51**

You know, it's really funny. I don't know if this is funny, but you know, there's that stamp, there's this standard comic who's on Saturday Night Live or he's one of the cast members, this guy, Marcelo Hernandez. He's in his like twenties. He did this stand up thing my wife showed me.

Ravi Katam - **34:02**

I know, I know. Marcelo Hernandez. Yeah, I know. He's super. He's sn on snl. Right.

Eric Zelman - **34:07**

So, yeah. So his Netflix thing, one of the things that his Netflix thing is he talks about how he has ADHD and how that really like, is just devastating for his, for dating. Because, because women like it when you pay attention to them. And, and, and he, and like one of his jokes is about how the thing that the. It's not about like how he says, it's not about like how you look or how much money you make. It's about. Do you ask follow up questions?

Ravi Katam - **34:44**

Yeah, yeah, I watched the whole thing. It's about like, you know, his household is full of women and then.

Eric Zelman - **34:52**

Right, yeah, you saw it. Yeah, yeah.

Ravi Katam - **34:55**

It's pretty funny.

Eric Zelman - **34:56**

I love that. So, yeah, I think that the AI has to know how to ask follow up questions that are based on listening first, you know, versus. Yeah, yeah. And that acknowledgement of what that person's. You know, again, what you said about uploading materials and spending time thinking about it and acknowledging that.

Ravi Katam - **35:14**

Yeah, yeah. I mean, I, I think that'll drastically improve the experience and also capturing the information. Right, Information as well. Then, then once I go through the exercise, I have all my talking points for the interview. You know, any interview, they're not gonna get much out of, outside of your resume. All the questions revolve around the resume. Right. And any question they ask you can actually bring them back to the resume. And this is what I had done. Right. So I think if you can improve that a bit and that'll help them actually get in, you know, get them ready for the interviews.

Eric Zelman - **36:14**

I, I will absolutely start working on this. I'm excited. Thank you.

Ravi Katam - **36:18**

Yeah, yeah.

Eric Zelman - **36:20**

So I'm going to get Steve to. I'm going to meet with Steve later this afternoon. I'm going to get him to test it. Who else? Lewis is going to test it. You know, everyone. There's nothing. There's nothing. I spoke to David the other night, which was. I went through the whole thing like, because I'd spoken to. I think I told you I spoke to David like last month for like a little while on the phone. But then the other night, like last weekend, I spent like an hour with him on the, you know, showing him kind of what it does and the deck and his, his reaction was exactly what you. What I said. His, his way of thinking about everything, which is don't write software.

Eric Zelman - **36:57**

Everything is unsafe, everything will be erased by like the new version of Claude or whatever because it'll just do all these things automatically where, you know, like, there's no safe place to write software. But he did think that first off, he doesn't know the space. So, you know, he, that was, you know, true, but that he thinks that maybe this is a tool. He thinks that what might happen is that people like me might end up having several tools like this and it might do like consultative work for companies. It was really interesting. I don't know if I, I don't think I told this story, but he literally said after I showed him this, he's like, you know, Brookdale doesn't have anyone who knows how to do this.

Eric Zelman - **37:49**

You should, I mean, he didn't say, go tell this person at Brookdale or that they need, you know, a job career discovery tool. I mean, it wasn't literally that, but he was saying that like this idea of people who are building out AI workflows or vibe coding or whatever I'm doing are things that he feels like that so many of the customers that we have had weren't capable. I mean, many are. Some are, you know, they're enormous companies and they're going to dig into this. But there's a lot of sort of that mid market, mid level companies that might, you know, like where did they begin?

Eric Zelman - **38:24**

And so he thought that maybe it isn't so much that you get hired by or that I would get hired by the company, you know, to build everything for them, but that they might look at it as like, you know, here's a person, here's a contractor. They do these five things, these 10 things. This is like their portfolio of. Of widgets.

Ravi Katam - **38:45**

So I thought, interesting. That's interesting because I saw a few companies looking for a customer success leader. Maybe I'll send you those. Those opportunities.

Eric Zelman - **39:01**

Yeah, I would love that. I applied to a couple of. A couple of like, you know, AI shops for CFs, but I didn't, you.

Ravi Katam - **39:09**

Know, again, no, these are specific to recruiting. Just, you know, they're. They're recruiting companies.

Eric Zelman - **39:16**

Wow, that'd be really interesting.

Ravi Katam - **39:18**

Yeah, because you developed, you know, you develop an application. Right. You can take that to them and talk to them about how you can improve their recruiting process.

Eric Zelman - **39:30**

That would be wild. That would be amazing. Oh, I also became. I incorporated myself this week. So I start. I filed the paperwork in Rhode island for.

Ravi Katam - **39:41**

Oh, nice.

Eric Zelman - **39:42**

Yeah, yeah. So I can file for grants and things. So I, I didn't name the company. It's just an llc. So I can, you know, like apply for government grants and things. But I don't know, dude, I don't know. I'm just trying to. I'm trying to. Trying to find where I can turn something into a business.

Ravi Katam - **40:03**

Yeah. If. If you're going through any customer success manager interviews and if you need practice and if you want to talk to me before interview, I can help you.

Eric Zelman - **40:15**

I would love that. I deeply appreciate that. That would be amazing. I need to get past. I mean, you know, I think I've said this too before. I think that the biggest problem, or no, I think I have a couple problems. And one is my. My career looks fragmented because I go from sales to support engineer to in my story, you know, to big tin can and kind of being like support and customer success to then going back to support. Right. Like the very beginning of Big Concand, there's no customer success. It's like me. But then a year later, a year or two later, then they're all these customer success people. Right. And like Craig and you know, it gets built out. So it's not clear what lane I'm in from the, from my story.

Eric Zelman - **41:07**

And then the thing I think that kills me when I apply for customer success jobs, I mean, amongst other things, is that I can talk about the total ARR. But I'm not like, looking at it. I'm not talking about it the way that you would have. Like, I managed X Book of Business. This is how much I held for my, you know, as a CS person. Right. I'm talking about it from the perspective of, you know, ARR and NRR for the entire company. Because I'm like, at that support level and I could probably, you know, Pat, again, Pat was like, just tell them what they want to hear and if they have any questions, have them call me. And so yes, I could just. And Maggio, you know, I could just make all this shit up. But, you know, I don't feel like that.

Eric Zelman - **42:08**

That's. That's. I. I just, I don't want to. I can't. I just don't feel like I can. I can bring myself to completely just say, you know, VP of customer success versus VP of support, because it's just not true, you know?

Ravi Katam - **42:24**

Yeah, yeah.

Eric Zelman - **42:25**

So I'm kind of, I think that I'm not trying to shoot myself in the foot, so to speak, but I'm trying to figure out what's a way for people to say, oh, Eric is flexible and he could be a CS IC or maybe a CS manager in a small company. And because I think all that is true, I'm just figuring out how do I. How do I get my resume and how do I get that narrative to work? Yeah. Because I get a lot because, you know, I'm like, I look at so many of these jobs and like, oh, I could totally do that, or I get this, or, you know, that's in my space or whatever.

Ravi Katam - **43:00**

Yeah, it's all about crafting. Crafting your store.

Eric Zelman - **43:03**

Right. Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **43:05**

You can do any job, but they don't know. They don't have the confidence you need to provide them. Yeah, right. But that's all about how you craft. Like, no, you have experience in customer success, you have experience in support, and you're the founding member. You built support obligation. Right. You built early customer success programs.

Eric Zelman - **43:34**

Yeah, yeah, and I lead with that. But.

Ravi Katam - **43:37**

And then, and then you built a lot of partner programs as well, right. T Mobile. You work with partners to implement and support them. Right. You've done a lot of things. So a lot of the companies value, that is, forget about what you actually did. Right. It's about what are the things that companies value? Building and sailing revenue, how much revenue we've impacted. Like, have you built high performance? Right. Have you built processes? And how building processes is one thing, but how the Processes, impact,.

Eric Zelman - **44:27**

How much of. I mean, so, I mean, not to. I mean, if you feel like you could share with me, I'd love to see your resume. How much do you give away in terms of, like, the. In terms of your metrics? And, and when you're talking about your roles, what are you saying?

Ravi Katam - **44:44**

On my resume. On my resume, I said, you know, I've. Me and my colleague, like, I was. I was one of the founding CSMs. CSM said they can. Then me and my peer, we built the CS organization from like, four people, because that's when I started making it right to 24. 24 People. And then we, you know, grew the business to $70 million. That's where my impact was. I only put that. But I tell them we've acquired and, you know, there were a lot of acquisitions and mergers that number. 70 Million is fluid for the period of 80 years. 70 Every year it's 120 now. It's like 250 to 300 million with everything. So I'm managing all of it, $70 million and hiding those 24 CSMs and putting together processes and building the CS organization.

Eric Zelman - **45:53**

Right.

Ravi Katam - **45:54**

So I'm giving all these numbers by. I'm also telling them where my impact is. Right. So what they is. Okay. They don't, you know, I've impacted some business. I'm being honest, but I also know about the business. I'm part of the leadership team that do that. Directly or indirectly. Or indirectly. So I'm still, you know, I. I can actually say that. 300 Million.

Eric Zelman - **46:28**

Right.

Ravi Katam - **46:28**

But my impact is 70 million, which is pretty significant. Right. So that's how I craft my story. Yeah. I didn't lie anything, but I threw in a lot of numbers.

Eric Zelman - **46:44**

Yeah, you did well. Yeah. So the 300 million, so the ARR is 130. Right. 140.

Ravi Katam - **46:53**

No, now it's 300. Like before when I left.

Eric Zelman - **46:55**

Oh, oh, when you look. Because the showpad thing.

Ravi Katam - **46:58**

Yeah, yeah.

Eric Zelman - **46:59**

Right, right. So you can say. Yeah, exactly. Fair. That's true. It's a year later. I forgot. I apologize.

Ravi Katam - **47:06**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **47:07**

Like, I'm. My brain is stuck in June of 2025.

Ravi Katam - **47:13**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **47:14**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **47:16**

So that's how I craft my story, like, without exaggerating stuff, without telling, you know, just, you know, telling the truth and not exaggerating. How do I craft my story and let them know that I can do this?

Eric Zelman - **47:33**

Right, right.

Ravi Katam - **47:36**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **47:38**

This is. This is kind of like. I mean, I definitely make modifications to this, but this is sort of the base I'LL just text

you my resume. This is kind of where the narrative I'm going is, I can just show it on screen. Actually, I'm sharing my screen still, right?

Ravi Katam - **48:08**

I don't think so.

Eric Zelman - **48:09**

Oh, I stopped. Okay, let me just do this. Sure.

Ravi Katam - **48:16**

Window.

Eric Zelman - **48:17**

I want to share this window. Okay. You see that?

Ravi Katam - **48:27**

Yeah, it's coming. You know, Eric, you should change that to customer experience because you know, success and support, you've done both, so. And you're pretty technical,.

Eric Zelman - **49:10**

Right? It's a good idea. I, so I, I try to put this idea of designing around human and automation based on kind of leading in this present world that we're in. And this, you know, you're going to be asked to sort of implement AI tools no matter where you go, whatever you do. So I think that's an important way of framing relevance. Right now I talk about the build out, Let's see, you know, I talk about budget, ownership, core skills. Let's see. I talk a little bit about CSAT and budget for support. I don't get into the company overall revenue because I just was like, how do I, you know, I guess I could put that in here about some, you know, support for X amount of revenue. Maybe I should do that.

Ravi Katam - **50:21**

Yeah, yeah, for sure.

Eric Zelman - **50:23**

I go into the director role. That's a, basically a continuation. So I mean half of my experience that really the stuff here is in the last 13 years. And then I talk a little bit about Aperion, that shop that Pat and I used to work at before Big Tin can. And then I just sort of just give highlights of earlier career stuff because I don't, you know, I, I think the other thing that potentially works against me is it's like, do you want to read three pages about me or do you really want to look at what I've been doing over the last 15 years? And it's probably the case that whatever I've been doing the last 15 years is the most important thing, you know? Yeah, I mean the Apple thing is nice to have, but does anyone remember Apple in 1998?

Eric Zelman - **51:10**

So I just, I keep it there, I'm not gonna get rid of it. But it's like, you know, and I talk about, you know, account revenue. I, I put numbers in for those things. And then, and then the other thing that I added, I think that this is actually helping. I hope this helps me. And this is something I've added in the last month. We'll see if it does. Is I think that the independent work, this, this job pipeline stuff, the scoring system I built and then this lens project, I think those two things are. I feel like I need to show what am I doing? You know, what have I been doing since, since July. So I think that this helps speak to that a bit.

Ravi Katam - **51:52**

Okay. Yeah. I mean, I'll take a look at it. Scroll up a little bit.

Eric Zelman - **52:00**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **52:02**

So if we put this into an ats.

Eric Zelman - **52:06**

Well, so every single time I do a job, every. I have 140 versions of this. So, I mean, whereas I'm showing you this is like a base. So if you said, if you can only put up one resume for like, whatever, I'd put this up. But if you said, here's a job, here's a jd, every JD means a slightly modified version of this that has keywords. So I can play the ATS bingo. You know what I mean? Because.

Ravi Katam - **52:38**

Initially, you know, what I do is like, initially I thought I was going to do the same thing, but I made sure all the words that the ATS needs in my resume, I only use one version.

Eric Zelman - **52:51**

It's probably a great idea. It's just, I just felt like, to be quite honest with you, is that like, you know, if you look at, I mean, you apply to, I mean, you're more successful than me, so maybe I should change my strategy for sure. But what I thought was, when I was working with earlier, you know, over the summer, what I was noticing was that I would create one version, one ATS optimized version that was like for, you know, say Director Customer Support or Director of Customer Success. Right? Just for some B2B SaaS company, whatever it was. And I would then take that resume and use it as a base for the next job.

Eric Zelman - **53:36**

And when I ran it through the ATS scoring for the JD for the next job for the other company, I would immediately notice that they, that it would change because they weren't. Because the ATS system then was looking for, you know, slightly different keywords so that every job, the keywords are different. So I felt like I didn't, I don't know. I mean, and you can tell me if I'm wrong, but I don't know how to make one version that has all the keywords that's going to work across lots of jobs. Because to get over that 75% keyword match, right, is difficult. Like, I would, I would be, I would make one version that was great for one job, and it would only be 60 for the next.

Eric Zelman - **54:26**

Even though, even though I feel like that they were almost the same thing, except that the people who wrote the JD just called. Just use different words for their, for their. Bingo. You know what I mean?

Ravi Katam - **54:42**

Maybe it's different for support roles, but customer success, all the, you know, the idea is like, am I impacting?

Eric Zelman - **54:52**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **54:53**

Am I building? Am I, you know.

Eric Zelman - **54:58**

Yeah. No, I, I don't disagree with that. I think that's true. I just thought there was more nuance between the roles, but I'll go back and look again because maybe I'm missing something.

Ravi Katam - **55:06**

Yeah. So, I mean, I don't know. The, the. I don't. I haven't seen support role responsibilities and requirements, so I don't know that I'm.

Eric Zelman - **55:19**

Pretty much just applying for CS jobs. Just so you know, like, I've applied to.

Ravi Katam - **55:23**

Oh, if you're applying for CS jobs, this is not enough.

Eric Zelman - **55:28**

Right?

Ravi Katam - **55:31**

This is, this is. You need to have revenue. You need to, you know. Well, take a look at the resume. I'll send you my resume.

Eric Zelman - **55:40**

Yeah, yeah. Okay. I would appreciate it. I'd love it. And, and that would be helpful.

Ravi Katam - **55:51**

Yeah. I thought you were applying for, you know, customer support job.

Eric Zelman - **55:55**

You know, I'm applying for. Well, I'm trying to apply for early stage, like companies where it's like they're looking for a founding CS person and I'm not. And again, this is just sort of a template. So often I think that, like, let me, let me try to prove this out. Hang on. So if I look at. Let's look at some jobs we've applied for recently. Like, here's one. This company, Revic, I applied for. Yeah. I think I need to put more of my. I think you're right. I need to put the revenue part in.

Ravi Katam - **56:41**

Especially if you're applying for customer success job right now. Are they.

Eric Zelman - **56:45**

But they just care about revenue.

Ravi Katam - **56:47**

They care about. Am I going to retain the customers? My book of business.

Eric Zelman - **56:52**

Yeah, yeah.

Ravi Katam - **56:54**

But have the experience.

Eric Zelman - **56:57**

Right.

Ravi Katam - **57:01**

I will go back about net retention. You need to. Revenue retention, gross revenue retention. You need to have expansion. That's a keyword there.

Eric Zelman - **57:15**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **57:17**

You need to have adoption and then you need to have account health risk. I don't say account health risk in your resume.

Eric Zelman - **57:26**

I didn't do that. Yeah, you're right.

Ravi Katam - **57:28**

You need to have forecasting, account management.

Eric Zelman - **57:35**

It's almost like I need to break out the early part of my career when I was. Or at Big Concan when I was doing More CS stuff because the. Or I had to figure out a way to weave all that together into me as a support vp because some of that I'm contributing to obviously, or in a way, all of it. But for instance, you know, two years ago, you and me talking, I'm not doing expand. I'm not thinking about expansion. Right. I'm thinking about retention. I'm always thinking about retention because I'm support. And I mean, you know, I'm thinking about, I mean support metrics but earlier in the big tin can world, like before you join. I could argue that at that point also because it's early stage, I'm worried about slightly different things, but the expand.

Eric Zelman - **58:32**

But it's all about expansion in the beginning, first couple of years.

Ravi Katam - **58:35**

It's just you should keep, you shouldn't be, you know, worried about somebody is going to come and say, hey, you didn't do that. You should confidently say that because you.

Eric Zelman - **58:45**

Well, I know, but I, that's what Pat said. He's like, you should say whatever you feel like is right.

Ravi Katam - **58:52**

No, I mean you know, you don't give enough credit for the work that you've done.

Eric Zelman - **59:01**

Yeah, right.

Ravi Katam - **59:02**

And there are people out there who's going, who's actually saying things.

Eric Zelman - **59:07**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **59:08**

So how do you compare? Like if I have two new people never met coming in and saying this.

Eric Zelman - **59:17**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **59:17**

And I was like hesitating to say that I've done that. I go with the confidence. Yeah, right.

Eric Zelman - **59:26**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **59:26**

It's all about perception as well. It's not about just, you know, truthfulness only gets you so far. Right. Right. Yeah, yeah. But how do you know it's all about how do we make sure the recruit is content that I can do this job even if I, you know, I did a few things, but I'm going to be confident in saying those things. I've done this. And everything else is like, oh, I don't know them, but I can do it. He believes me because he would believe me because I. Something. I'll start with the con. The things I've done with a lot of content saying that.

Eric Zelman - **01:00:10**

Right, right.

Ravi Katam - **01:00:12**

These things. I've never done it. I kind of know what I.

Eric Zelman - **01:00:19**

Okay, let me. If you could. I mean, seeing your resume would be really helpful. Seeing the output that you got from the. The other thing is if you could send if the output from the two hour session with the lens, that would be interesting too. Just to see what it output. And if you could Also send me. So you said you uploaded your resume and one other LinkedIn. If you could send me those two things because I want to go and validate it against the latest bill.

Ravi Katam - **01:00:57**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **01:00:58**

The output that you got, the Resume and the LinkedIn. Those. Sorry, those three things. Those three things that would sort of help me to reconstruct a bit more about if it's doing the right thing, if it's working the right way. Having that output would be useful, but also for me, for my job search for myself. You know, understanding how you as a CS leader, frame yourself, that's. That would be huge. I would really appreciate that.

Ravi Katam - **01:01:28**

Yeah, yeah. Okay.

Eric Zelman - **01:01:32**

And if you want. And if also, I mean, if you want. Well, let's see how these next four or five interviews go. And you're being, you know, you're off on your way and finding a job quickly and you'll get something you want. If you ever. In the next couple of weeks, want me to think about building out, because I was sort of thinking it would be interesting. I don't want to drag you into hours and hours of work, but it would be interesting to build my job pipeline against all the VCs with you as the candidate versus me.

Ravi Katam - **01:02:06**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **01:02:07**

To see what that would look like. Like, for instance, like, I, I mean, it might take a while to actually get this to. It to work, but I, I have about. I don't know, the air table has about 3, 3600 startups. So, you know, and I'm like, what would it look like if Ravi was looking at those startups versus Eric? You know, like, how would that be different?

Ravi Katam - **01:02:33**

Because, yeah, that'll be great.

Eric Zelman - **01:02:36**

Yeah. And it might be cool. And, and it also might just be cool. Like I'm, I mean, or for me, I'd like to maybe just do it as an exercise just to see what the results would be. And then I was thinking earlier that, you know, I could do that

work. You don't have to do that work. So it doesn't take hours of your time. It's really on me. And then what I could do at the end of that is present you with a few different models or a few different outcomes based on how the scoring might change. So like a report of saying, you know, based on what I know about you, here's the top 50, you know, and why, or the top 25. Right.

Eric Zelman - **01:03:20**

That you should look into and we can discuss whether any of these made any sense as fits for you.

Ravi Katam - **01:03:26**

Okay. Yeah. That'll be good. Yeah, for sure.

Eric Zelman - **01:03:32**

Thank you so much for. For. For letting me collaborate with you on this. It's like super.

Ravi Katam - **01:03:37**

It's amazing. Yeah, of course.

Eric Zelman - **01:03:39**

It's super useful.

Ravi Katam - **01:03:40**

Oh, of course. Of course. Yeah. Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **01:03:42**

So what are you gonna do this weekend?

Ravi Katam - **01:03:45**

Playing Batman and celebrating Easter with friends. Like, these are Europeans, so.

Eric Zelman - **01:03:52**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **01:03:55**

Romanians. So they have Easter.

Eric Zelman - **01:03:58**

They have the Eastern Orthodox Easter, right? Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **01:04:02**

The Sunday Easter party and Saturdays Batman.

Eric Zelman - **01:04:07**

Dude, I, I, you know, I love, like, you. You probably the same experience, right? You didn't grow up with Easter. I didn't grow up with Easter. I wish that someone would invite me to Easter parties because all the food looks so amazing.

Ravi Katam - **01:04:16**

No, I grew up with Easter.

Eric Zelman - **01:04:18**

Oh, you did?

Ravi Katam - **01:04:20**

Because my. My. My family.

Eric Zelman - **01:04:23**

Oh, I didn't know that. Oh, see, I made a huge assumption. Now I'm wrong. So.

Ravi Katam - **01:04:29**

Yeah, I mean, I. I don't follow religion, but my family very religious, so I. I do not like that part. But it's family. You can't do much about it.

Eric Zelman - **01:04:47**

So I. I know I've asked you this before. So now that you're in between jobs, are you getting more pressure to go home for a while or like to visit, or are they. They backing off of you?

Ravi Katam - **01:04:57**

There's all this pressure to go and visit, but, yeah, you have to just manage it because it's. It's just go to India expensive. And.

Eric Zelman - **01:05:16**

Yeah.

Ravi Katam - **01:05:19**

And I don't have a job, so I probably should not spend that much money traveling.

Eric Zelman - **01:05:24**

That's a good excuse.

Ravi Katam - **01:05:26**

Yeah. Yeah. Maybe once they find something and then I have some time, I can go. At least a demonstration.

Eric Zelman - **01:05:35**

I'm just jealous of people who are traveling right now. That's really all. I'm. I'm just asking where people are going, what they're doing, because I just. I'm like. I'm just. I'm bored at home and I'm like, I gotta get a job. So anyhow, have an awesome weekend. If you could sell me those things, that would be amazing. I'll start to work out, like, building a Ravi job pipeline and figure out what that would look like.

Ravi Katam - **01:05:58**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **01:05:59**

And we can iterate on that. And that's it. Thank you so much for. For hanging out today.

Ravi Katam - **01:06:07**

Yeah, for sure. Yeah. I mean, I. Let me know if I can help you in any way. You know, definite resume.

Eric Zelman - **01:06:15**

I need to. I need to update that 100%. I got to put the. The numbers there. You know, I also, I mean, you know, to be honest, I get so confused because I've had numbers in Resumes. I've had so many versions of my resume, I'm like, oh, that doesn't have any numbers. Right. You know, and like, it's such an obvious thing. But then I'm like, how did I miss that? And so this is.

Ravi Katam - **01:06:35**

Yeah. Anyhow, initially I was creating different resumes for different, you know, for different reasons. Then I realized no matter how what I do, it's still, I have to craft my story in a way that it makes sense, it provides content. And I was able to do that somehow in the resume, like what I've done without exaggerating.

Eric Zelman - **01:07:06**

Right.

Ravi Katam - **01:07:10**

So I could exaggerate a little bit more, but I didn't do that.

Eric Zelman - **01:07:15**

No, I know. I get the message. I get the message. I'm going to go spend feverishly, work on it this afternoon and see what happens when I start applying for some jobs next week.

Ravi Katam - **01:07:27**

Yeah. And also, you know, you sent me that, you know, that funny site, like how the corporate jargon is like when you.

Eric Zelman - **01:07:37**

Oh, yeah, the LinkedIn.

Ravi Katam - **01:07:38**

Yeah, LinkedIn profiles and resumes are like that. What you did. You have to say it in a way that it looks grand. It appears.

Eric Zelman - **01:07:51**

Yeah, yeah. And also you know, you have to synchronize the two. Because the other thing that the reality is that if I'm applying for support cs, you know, this sort of spectrum of jobs, they always ask, where's your LinkedIn? So the thing is that the narrative has to be consistent between the LinkedIn and the resume. I mean, I think it's pretty obvious, but, you know, it's just one of those things of like, it kind of keeps you in your swim lane, you know, so.

Ravi Katam - **01:08:23**

Yeah, so I think what we need to do is like one resume, but actually tells you. Tells them your story.

Eric Zelman - **01:08:34**

Yeah, well, and then that's usually where I. I mean, that's the. The COVID letter is usually, you know, the hope. The hope is that the COVID letters where you can expand on the story and how it relates to the job. You know, like wine.

Ravi Katam - **01:08:50**

He has to be in the resume. They don't even look at the car. They don't look at the car letter.

Eric Zelman - **01:08:55**

Yeah, yeah.

Ravi Katam - **01:08:57**

The resume has to pass first.

Eric Zelman - **01:09:01**

True.

Ravi Katam - **01:09:04**

But I'll send you my resume, take a look at it and how it looks, and maybe you can give me some pointers. But that's what I did. Like, how can I tell my story with my resume. And I can expand more on when I actually get a call? So, yeah, like, well, let's definitely work on your resume. Let's make sure that it's. It's enticing and hits those ats.

Eric Zelman - **01:09:45**

Yeah, I will. Thank you so much for your time. I'm gonna go start working on that as soon as.

Ravi Katam - **01:09:50**

Okay. All right. Have a good weekend. We'll talk soon.

Eric Zelman - **01:09:54**

Take care, Robbie.